

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Illuminated: A Cinematic Journey to Deeper Spirituality
Generosity's Transforming Power
February 9th, 2025



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540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in- Residence

Improvisation on BUNESSAN and REGENT SQUARE
O Dieu de clémence, Viens par ta présance (Jean Romary Grosjean)
Ecclusiastics (Charles Mingus, arr. C. Bull)
Invention dans le style ancien (Henriette Renié)
Prelude in D minor (Heinrich Scheidemann)
Fugue in D minor, BWV 538/2 (Johann Sebastian Bach)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

Words of Gathering

Anita and Tom Reinehr

In this place, we believe in a world made new,
where mourning is turned into dancing,
and souls are set free.

*We believe in a world where all are heard
and rivers flow where each may drink,
a world where the harvest becomes
a banquet for all.*

The God of all creation has given us
a world of beauty.
God has given us a place of plenty
where no one needs to hunger...
if we learn to share.

This morning we ask that our hearts may be opened
in order that we might understand compassion.
We ask that our minds will be opened
so that we may receive the courage
to count the cost.

*We ask for the strength to let go of all that binds us
to our wealth and possessions.*

And we ask, that God will guide us as we work
to bring about God's dream for the world,
a world where we all are part of one community,
a community filled with justice and peace.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand now in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

Come, See the Fullness

BUNESSAN

God the Creator gave in abundance
All of the wonder we now behold;
Colors of glory, everyday beauty,
Echo the story of God's deep love.

Bold as the sunlight, tender as nightfall,
Love shaped the heav'n's height; love filled the seas.
Love formed the flowers, called for the living;
Marked out the hours of time to be.

Come, see the fullness – Life we've been given;
Beauty and promise, mystr'y and hope.
Laughter and weeping, vision and purpose;
Friends for the keeping, strength for the road.

Open our hearts wide, teach us your wisdom
Lest our days pass by empty and small.
May we be witness with your creation –
To your great kindness given to all.

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Michael Lehman

Generous Creator,
we celebrate our lives and this world.

We are blessed with so many gifts:
the circle of loved ones,
far and wide.

The food we have for sharing
and for those who provide it.

*This place we name home,
and all life that surrounds us.*

This time, which we have been given
to flourish in your love.

*We rejoice in this abundance
and we give thanks for your grace.*

This morning, Spirit of God,
fill our hearts with joy
and our moments with wonder
as we gather to celebrate
the web of your creation.

*May this time we share fill us
with the generous warmth and joy of your presence.
Amen and Amen.*

***Introit**

*"Fantasy on Immortal, Invisible"
Cathedral Ringers, Grace Sheldon Williams, Director*

DEREK HAKES

***The Lord's Prayer**

Anita Reinehr

*Our [God], who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kingdom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kingdom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever.
Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

*Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.*

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

*Happiness doesn't lie in conspicuous consumption and the relentless amassing of useless things.
Happiness lies in the person sitting beside you and your ability to talk to them.
Happiness is clear-headed human interaction and empathy. Happiness is home. And home is not
a house – home is a mythological concept.
It is a state of mind. A place of communion and unconditional love.
It is where, when you cross its threshold, you finally feel at peace.*

*This morning, in this sacred place we call home,
May the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!*

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition
from the Gospel of Luke

Anita & Tom Reinehr

*This is the Gospel of Grace.
Thanks be to God!*

Prayers with the People

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Gracious God, we are gathered here this morning to bask in your beauty and reflect on your place in our lives.

Too often we forget how you feed us, whisper in our ears, and sprinkle our sleep with dreams.

Help us to remember that through you we are all joyfully connected.

We pray for our awareness of your presence among us, God.

Our burdens can be great, and we can feel all alone.

Our hands long to feel the touch of another,

and our hearts long for reconciliation, compassion, and understanding.

So on this day, as we open our hearts to you Strong and Gentle God, may we also open our hearts to one another.

As we breathe in your love, help us to know we are worthy of that love.

Help us feel your touch, and know your grace and mercy.

We pray for your presence with all the creatures of the earth, for your Spirit, O God, lives within and connects us all.

Thank you for the many gifts and blessings in our lives.

And as we give love, may we also receive love, from you and from each other.

Amen and Amen.

Meditation Anthem

"O Sacrum Convivium"

Cathedral Choir

KEVIN ALLEN

"O sacred feast, wherein Christ is received; the memorial of his passion is renewed; the soul is filled with grace; and a pledge of future glory is given to us."

Sermon

Generosity's Transforming Power

Rev. Lehman

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Tanaka Pack & Rev. Lehman

O taste and see

the goodness and generosity of God,

who calls us to the table

and meets us in every feast!

We take the bread as Jesus did,

we break it, bless it, and share it,

remembering the goodness of God.

We take the cup as Jesus did,

we pour it, bless it, and share it,

remembering the table is set for all.

Gathered, kneaded, rising, broken,
you who eat are yet the feast.
So fashion wide your banquet table;
by your lives may all be fed.

*On this day,
and on all the days to come,
may the love of Christ
be our center, our focus,
our practice, our feast.*

Prayer of Blessing

O God, we know
that this food we are about to share
has already been blessed
by you
by those who planted it
by those who tended it
by those who gathered it
by those who prepared it.

So bless us, O God,
that we may taste and know
its blessedness,
as we feast with one another
at this table you have prepared.

[jrichardson]

*We pray this in the name
of the Christ, whose table
we now share.
Amen and Amen.*

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Tanaka Pack

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how it's given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also be available at the exits when the service ends with baskets to collect gifts.

Offertory

**"Largo and Alleluia" from *In Furore*
Laurel Irene, Soloist**

ANTONIO VIVALDI

*"Then my weeping will turn to joy as my heart is softened toward you.
Stir me, Jesus, and joyful weeping will warm my heart. Hallelujah!"*

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Prayer of Offering**

Tom Reinehr

Holy One, as we now bring these offerings of
our time, our gifts and talents, and our money,
along with our gratitude and joy for this life we share,
help us to remember all those who are vulnerable to suffering and injustice.

And then, O God, make us into people who are becoming
more gracious in our giving, more tender in our care,
and more fierce in our protection of all your people.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen.

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Lehman

We all drink from one water
We all breathe from one air
We rise from one ocean
And live under one sky
Remember: we are one.

The newborn baby cries the same
The laughter of children is universal
Everyone's blood is red
And our hearts beat the same song
Remember: we are one.

We are all siblings
Only one family, only one earth
Together we live
And together we die
Remember: we are one.

Peace be on you,
My siblings,
Peace be on you
- Anwar Fazal, Malaysia - adapted

Choral Response

"Praise The Lord"
Cathedral Choir, Brandon Harris, *Conductor*

FLORENCE PRICE

*Hymn for the Journey

Come and Feast, for All Are Welcomed

REGENT SQUARE

Come and feast, for all are welcomed at God's table spread with love.
Come proclaim God's grace and goodness in, around us, and above.
Come and feast, for all are welcomed at God's table spread with love.

Here we nurture and encourage as we share this common meal,
While we foster deep communion and our inner selves reveal.
Here we nurture and encourage as we share this common meal.

See the chalice lifted upward; smell the fragrant, broken bread;
Taste the gifts from field and vineyard; hear the words that Jesus said:
'Eat and drink, and in remembrance touch your souls with **cup** and bread.'

With the Spirit blessed commission, 'Go and serve this meal to all,'
Take its love and peaceful vision into every banquet hall.
Go and serve as nourished people, gladly feeding one and all!

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*
Moderato in D minor (Heinrich Scheidemann) and Improvisation

Inside The Music

"As we continue to honor Black History Month, we feature works of contemporary composer Kevin Allen and 20th Century icon Florence Price. Given the theme of the feast this week, I wanted to sing a setting of "O Sacrum Convivium." This short 13th century poem has been the subject of several masterpieces across the last four hundred years. As I was listening through some of my favorites, I decided to look into what living composers had spent time with it. After reading through around 40 different, magical settings, I came across Kevin Allen's and it spoke to me. Allen is a Chicago resident and a life-long Catholic. He speaks of the music of the Catholic church with love and reverence. It is his personal language, having been steeped in the traditions from an early age. His "O Sacrum Convivium" setting has some things in common with past masterpieces. It is relatively brief, based on the original chant and therefore is generally modal in its harmonic approach, and treats each phrase of the text as a singular moment distinguished by harmonic markers. He draws enough on past traditions that when you hear it, you might not know that it's a contemporary piece. This kind of homage is a common approach in Catholic composer circles. Allen brings delightful personal touches into his homage to tradition that make the piece sparkle. To understand Allen's piece, we have to remember that in the Catholic tradition, the elements of communion are said to physically change from earthly elements of bread and wine into the Christ. His piece begins in C# minor, with harmonic references that make us think that he will feature C# minor throughout. By the middle of the first phrase, we realize that instead of C#, he is going to take us through a slow transition into something new. The lowered 7th scale degree of B becomes the change agent, and the focus of the first phrase's conclusion. From there he wanders through multiple key areas, using choice dissonances as elevation points and deft counterpoint to keep our ears simultaneously awake to change and calm. Before the final phrase, he has taken us as far away harmonically as possible, to a key area a tritone away on G. From G he slips back to B as a setup for the final phrase. As we sing of future glory through love, he takes us rapidly back through all the key areas for the final acknowledgement of change. We do return to C#, but not the same one on which we began.

Believing now in the dominance of B, when the C# major chord arrives as the final chord of the song, it is no longer the expected focus, but a refreshed surprise. Allen invites us to consider how renewal through the process of intentional communion has a profound impact. Florence Price was the first Black woman in America to have a symphonic work performed by a major symphony orchestra, in 1933. She has an undisputed reputation as a virtuosic organ composer, and composer of solo and orchestral works. Her choral pieces, though few, meet the same bar. Her setting of Psalm 117, "Praise the Lord," sounds like an organ and brass fanfare throughout. In the softer B section of the song, she highlights the Psalmists' reasons for praise. God is kind and merciful, and God's truth endures. These featured qualities reminded me of how I feel after a prepared feast by a loving host. Celebration of the gift of their preparation and care flows inevitably." ~ Dr. David Harris